Meta Ads Mastery for Ecommerce

GPLMart - practical digital resources for ecommerce sellers, developers and creators.

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Chapter 1 - How Meta ads actually work (the mental model)

The auction in one paragraph

[object Object]

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Ad Rank = Bid x Estimated Action Rate x Ad Quality
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- **Bid**: what you're willing to pay (automated in most campaigns now)
- **Estimated Action Rate**: how likely Meta thinks someone is to convert - driven by
your creative and landing page
- **Ad Quality**: feedback from users - thumbs down, hide ad, negative feedback kills
your rank

Translation: great creative + good landing page = cheaper clicks than big budgets with
bad creative. This is why small stores can beat big brands.

### The learning phase

Every new ad set goes through ~50 conversion events of learning. During this:
- Don't touch the ad set (no budget changes >20%, no edits)
- Performance is volatile - judge after learning completes
- If it doesn't exit learning, the ad set is too small/narrow or conversions aren't
tracked

### The 3-campaign structure that works


1. PROSPECTING (cold traffic) - find new buyers
   - Broad or interest targeting
   - Goal: purchases or add-to-cart

2. RETARGETING (warm traffic) - convert browsers
   - Website visitors 7-30 days, cart abandoners, product viewers
   - Goal: purchases

3. ADVANTAGE+ / ASC (scaling) - let Meta find buyers
   - Only when you have conversion data (30+/month)


Never run one campaign "targeting everyone". Structure is how you control spend and
learn what works.

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Chapter 2 - The creative that wins (80% of your results)

What actually stops the scroll

People don't scroll slowly - they scroll FAST. Your ad has <1 second to earn attention.

Winning creative patterns:

1. **Problem callout**: "Tired of [pain]?" - speaks to their frustration
2. **Curiosity gap**: "Wait till you see this..." - open loop
3. **Social proof**: "10,000+ customers can't be wrong"
4. **Demo/visual proof**: product working, before/after, texture shots
5. **Offer-led**: discount, free shipping, bundle - for warm audiences

Creative formats ranked for ecommerce

Format	Best for	Cost	Notes
UGC-style video (person using product)	Cold traffic	Medium	Highest trust, best CTR
Product demo video (hands-only)	Cold + warm	Low	Scales well, easy to produce
Carousel (multiple products/features)	Catalog stores	Low	Good for showcasing range
Static image	Retargeting	Lowest	Works for offers, proof
Testimonial/review graphic	Warm traffic	Low	Social proof converts

The hook rule

The first 1.5-3 seconds decide everything:

- Text overlay in first frame: "POV: you finally found..." or "Stop scrolling - this is for you"
- Movement in first frame: hands picking up product, result shot
- NEVER: logo intro, slow pan, "Hi guys welcome back" - dead on arrival

Creative testing system

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Test 3 angles x 2-3 creatives each = 6-9 ads
Budget:  ¹300-500/day total during test
Run: 5-7 days minimum
Judge: CTR >1% cold / >2% warm + add-to-cart rate
Kill: ads with spend > ¹500 and zero purchases
Winner: gets scaled + 3 new creative variations
```

Never judge an ad in 24 hours. Never kill an ad during learning phase.

Chapter 3 - Targeting: broad vs detailed (the 2025 answer)

Broad targeting (the default for most stores)

Target: India (or your market) + age 18-65+ + let Meta find buyers.

Why it works now: Meta's algorithm has more data than your interest assumptions. Detailed targeting often OVER-restricts and raises costs.

Detailed targeting (use for specific cases)

- Niche products where broad wastes spend (industrial equipment, specialized tools)
- Lookalike audiences built from your buyers (1-3% LAL)
- Interest stacks for very specific demos

Custom audiences (your goldmine)

Build these FIRST, before spending on cold traffic:

Audience	Size	Use
Website visitors 7d	Small	Retargeting - hot
Website visitors 30d	Medium	Retargeting
Add-to-cart abandoners	Small	Highest-intent retargeting
Product viewers (specific)	Small	Product-specific retargeting
Past purchasers	Medium	Cross-sell, new arrivals
Email/WhatsApp list	Varies	Upload as Custom Audience

Lookalike audiences

- Source: your PURCHASERS (not visitors) - quality in, quality out
- Start 1% (most similar), expand to 2-3% if needed
- India is a smaller market - 1-3% is usually enough reach

Chapter 4 - Budgets & bidding (the numbers that matter)

Starting budget (India ecommerce)

- Minimum viable test: ¹500-1000/day total across campaigns
- Comfortable test: ¹1000-2000/day
- Below ¹300/day: not enough data, results are noise

Budget split

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60-70% !’ Prospecting (new customers = growth)
20-30% !’ Retargeting (cheaper conversions)
10%   !’ Testing new creatives/audiences
```

Bidding strategy

Stage	Strategy	Why
Launch	Lowest cost (auto)	Let Meta find cheap results first
Scaling	Cost cap or ROAS goal	Control costs once you know your numbers
Mature	Highest value or ROAS	Optimize for revenue, not just conversions

The math that decides everything

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Break-even ROAS = 100 / Gross margin %
Example: 40% margin !’ break-even ROAS = 2.5x
Target ROAS = break-even + 20-30% buffer = 3.0-3.3x

If your AOV is  ¹800 and target ROAS is 3x:
Max allowable CPA =  ¹800 / 3 =  ¹267 per purchase
```

If Meta can't get CPA under your max, fix: creative, product page, offer, or product choice - in that order.

Chapter 5 - The campaign build (step by step)

Prospecting campaign

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Campaign: [Product] - Prospecting - [Date]
Ad set: Broad India 18-65, Advantage+ placements
Budget:  ¹500-800/day, lowest cost bid
Ads: 3-6 creatives (UGC video, demo video, carousel)
Pixel/CAPI: purchase event firing correctly
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Retargeting campaign

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Campaign: [Store] - Retargeting - [Date]
Ad set 1: ATC abandoners 7d - offer-focused creative
Ad set 2: Product viewers 14d - product reminder creative
Ad set 3: Past buyers 30d - new arrivals/cross-sell
Budget:  ¹200-400/day
```

India-specific essentials

- **COD offers in creative**: "COD available" lifts conversion 10-20% for Indian audiences
- **WhatsApp CTA**: click-to-WhatsApp ads for high-consideration products
- **Regional creatives**: Hindi/regional language ads outperform English for mass-market India
- **Festive timing**: Diwali, Eid, Republic Day = CPMs spike but conversion spikes more
- plan inventory and budgets ahead

Chapter 6 - Scaling without breaking

The 20% rule

Increase budget max 20% every 3-4 days when profitable. Bigger jumps reset learning and tank performance.

Scaling hierarchy

1. **First**: duplicate winning ad set !’ increase budget gradually
2. **Then**: new creatives for the same audience (creative fatigue is real)
3. **Then**: new audiences (new interests, lookalikes, broad expansion)
4. **Last**: new campaigns (only when existing ones max out)

Creative fatigue signals

- CTR dropping week over week
- Frequency >3-4 on prospecting
- CPA rising while spend holds
- "Hide ad" feedback increasing

Fix: new hooks, new formats, new angles - not bigger budgets.

When to kill

- Ad set spends 3x your target CPA with zero purchases
- CTR <0.8% after 5+ days and decent spend
- ROAS <50% of break-even for 2+ weeks

Killing losers fast is a skill. Sentimentality with ad spend is expensive.

Chapter 7 - Tracking & attribution (know your real numbers)

Pixel + Conversions API (CAPI)

- Install Meta Pixel on every page
- Fire events: ViewContent, AddToCart, InitiateCheckout, Purchase
- Enable CAPI (server-side) - browser-only tracking loses 20-40% of conversions to ad blockers/iOS
- Test with Meta's Event Manager - verify Purchase fires with correct value

Attribution reality

- Meta claims more than Google Analytics shows - both are "right" (different windows)
- Trust: platform-reported ROAS for optimization, GA4/Shopify for actual revenue
- Look at MER (total revenue / total ad spend) as your north star - blended, can't be faked

Weekly numbers to check

Spend | Purchases | CPA | ROAS | CTR | CPM | Frequency
Per campaign, per ad set, per creative

Chapter 8 - The 30-day launch plan for a new store

Week 1: Setup
- Pixel + CAPI installed and tested
- 6-9 creatives produced (3 angles)
- Prospecting + retargeting campaigns built

- ¹500-800/day budget live

Week 2: Test & learn
- Let learning complete (~50 conversions)
- Kill clear losers, note winners
- First customer reviews coming in !’ add to creative

Week 3: Optimize
- Scale winning ad sets +20%
- New creative batch for winners (variations)
- Fix product pages with high ATC but low purchase

Week 4: Scale or pivot
- If ROAS > target: scale budget +20%, add lookalikes
- If ROAS < target: diagnose - creative? offer? product? landing page?
- Document what worked for next product launch

Chapter 9 - Common mistakes that burn money

Mistake	Cost	Fix
Killing ads in learning phase	Reset learning, wasted spend	Wait for 50 conversions or 7 days
One ad to rule them all	No data on what works	3+ creatives minimum per ad set
Broad "targeting everyone" in ONE campaign	Can't control spend	Split prospecting/retargeting/testing
No negative feedback monitoring	Ad quality tanks, costs rise	Check quality ranking weekly
Scaling too fast	Learning resets, CPA spikes	Max +20% every 3-4 days
Ignoring landing page	Paying for clicks that don't convert	Fix page before blaming ads
No CAPI	20-40% conversions invisible	Server-side tracking mandatory
Judging on day 1-2	Noise, not signal	Judge after learning + 5+ days

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Chapter 10 - Your Meta ads scoreboard

Track weekly per campaign:

- Spend vs budget
- Purchases & CPA vs target
- ROAS vs break-even
- CTR & CPM trends
- Creative fatigue (frequency, CTR decline)
- Top 3 creatives by ROAS

By day 30 you'll know: which products sell via ads, what creative angles work for your audience, your real CPA/ROAS, and whether paid traffic is a channel you can scale - or an expensive lesson. Both are valuable; only one is profitable.

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